HEART CONDITIONS

Managing diabetes and heart health

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

How are diabetes and heart health linked?

Diabetes can affect your heart as well as your blood sugar. High blood sugar can damage blood vessels and nerves that help control the heart. Blood pressure and cholesterol also affect your risk. Ask your healthcare team how your diabetes and heart treatments work together. [1,2,3]

Understand the checks

An A1C test gives information about average blood sugar over recent months. Blood pressure checks and cholesterol tests provide different information. Ask when each check is due and what targets are appropriate for you. Keep results in one folder so different clinicians can review the same information. Do not assume that reaching a sugar goal means your other heart risks no longer need attention. [1,4]

Prepare for activity safely

Activity can help manage blood sugar, but exercise after a heart event needs an individual plan. Tell the rehabilitation team which diabetes medicines you take and whether you have had low blood sugar. Ask whether you should check glucose around sessions, how meals fit the schedule, and what supplies to carry. Follow the agreed instructions rather than making changes based on another patient’s experience. [1,2]

Know your low-sugar plan

Ask your diabetes clinician to explain the symptoms and treatment of low blood sugar, including what to do if you cannot safely swallow or need another person’s help. Write down the plan and share it with someone you trust. Do not begin a session when you feel unwell without telling the team. If you become confused, collapse, or have severe symptoms, seek urgent help.

Bring meals into the discussion

Food advice should account for both your diabetes and heart condition. Show the team a typical day of meals, snacks, and drinks. Ask about portions, meal timing, and changes that fit your budget. If you also have kidney disease or a fluid restriction, mention it. A single online diet may overlook those needs. Avoid replacing prescribed treatment with supplements advertised as natural cures.

Coordinate medicines and appointments

Keep an updated list of all prescriptions and show it at every visit. Ask who is overseeing changes and when follow-up is needed. If different instructions seem to conflict, ask the clinicians to clarify them. Plan refills before medicines run out and arrange tests before they are due. Tell the team if paying for diabetes care and heart care at the same time is difficult.

Choose one clear next step

Choose one next step, such as confirming a test appointment or reviewing exercise precautions. Ask who will help you act on it. Keep your diabetes and heart care connected, with a clear way to report problems.

References

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3. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Diabetic heart disease. https://medlineplus.gov/diabeticheartdisease.html

4. National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases. (n.d.). Diabetes, heart disease, and stroke. https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/diabetes/overview/preventing-problems/heart-disease-stroke

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